

Chapter

From Praise to Self- Realisation — The Evolution of Sanatan Dharma



Introduction: The Veda as a Living Journey

We often think of the Veda as a closed book, written once and for all. In this chapter Acharya Upendra Ji presents the Veda as an **evolving journey** — in which human beings first praised nature, then added ritual, then saw that ritual turn into a business, and finally, through one sage's rebellion, arrived at the Self-knowledge of the Upanishads.

The four parts of the Veda — **Mantra Samhita**, **Brahmana**, **Aranyaka** and **Upanishad** — emerged one after another in this order. Acharya Ji explains each part with a simple, homely example, and at the end shows, through the Bhagavad Gita, which part of the Veda the seeker has to reach.

1. Mantra Samhita: Praising the Guest

The first part of the Veda is the **Mantra Samhita**:

"The first part is called Mantra Samhita. Mantra Samhita means offering praise to the Supreme Lord, and so on."

To explain it, Acharya Ji asks us to imagine a guest:

"A man is coming — your guest, an **atithi**, isn't he? We invited him with great respect, we called him in. So think of it at home: he arrives, and it's 'Come in' — and for two hours you only speak nice things."

"And now: 'That's enough praise, now go' — would that work?"

How was this praise born? In the society of that time, when there was no year-round business but farming, people of Brahmin intellect had time and a calm mind:

"They would think: how does this nature run, how sincerely it works — that is all they observed — how the river keeps flowing. **It is high time I should appreciate.**"

The other varnas were busy with their own work, but the rishis and munis went into solitude:

"So the rishis and munis meditated on nature — how sincerely it comes and goes, how the sun comes. **While praising it, composition happened on its own**, and it was converted into the Mantra Samhita."

In other words, the first part of the Veda did not come from a command; it sprang spontaneously out of **gratitude** towards nature.

2. The Brahmana Portion: Love Is Expressed in Action

But praise alone does not complete hospitality to a guest:

"Arre, if someone has come, then at least something — offer a laddu, give some water, give something. If they have come, give them something, then we'll talk."

From here arose the second part of the Veda, the **Brahmana** — from which the methods of worship came:

"From that arose **shodashopachara puja**, **panchopachara puja** and so on — all of that, some kriya (ritual action)."

(**Shodashopachara** — worship with sixteen offerings; **panchopachara** — worship with five offerings.)

Acharya Ji describes with light humour how this ritual kept growing — offering water to the sun, then an idol at home:

"Physically he cannot eat anything. Arre, the water doesn't reach up there — it falls on the head of the person on the floor below, and there's a complaint! Then in one's own house — then he came into the idol."

"So **some new kriya kept on evolving**. That part is called Brahmana."

The name of the Brahmin varna is connected to this too:

"One who walks the path of Brahman is called a Brahmin; he has only one aim — to go towards Brahman. So the action part — **yajna, dana, tapa, offerings, worship — that part of the Veda is called Brahmana.**"

Acharya Ji gives the essence of this portion in one sentence:

"If a guest comes, praise alone won't do; along with it some action is needed too. **Love is expressed in action.**"

And he drives it home with examples from life:

"The wife said, 'I love you very much, but I won't make tea for you.' Saying that doesn't work."

"Shri Krishna would often give gifts to Radha... Kusum Sarovar... Radha Kund, Krishna Kund. He used to give. He was a king, wasn't he — he gave gifts of that level."

"Merely saying it orally is a different thing. The king will say, 'I love you very much,' and later impose heavy taxes — no, it must show in action. He built roadways, built everything — **it is real love.**"

"He sat down with a japa mala and praised all day, 'honey, honey, honey, honey' — does that work?... **Praise alone is of no use; action is needed along with it.**"

3. The Beginning of Religion: Nature Worship and Ancestor Worship

Citing Swami Vivekananda, Acharya Ji turns to the history of religion:

"Swami Vivekananda has described this very well in Bhakti Yoga, and in Karma Yoga as well."

The Brahmin class began thanking nature in their own ashrams — and Acharya Ji asks:

"In their own huts, in their own ashrams, they started saying thank you, thank you, thank you, and doing the actions for it. **Was the intention bad?**"

"They say, **religion started with ancestor worship and nature worship** — the worship of nature and the worship of the ancestors."

Ancestor worship was born of the same curiosity:

"At some point the first man must have died... 'Arre, he was here yesterday, where did he go?' So he started thinking... then actions for him — then shraddha, pinda, everything must have started."

Even in today's shraddha both elements — praise and action — can be seen. And the worship of deities also began here, because:

"The devatas started from this, because that is what could be seen. I first have to go **from form to the formless**, haven't I? It was said — whatever is seen, that alone will be worshipped."

4. The Birth of Dakshina: "You Will Have to Give Your Own Thanks"

Seeing the benefits the rishis were receiving, the Kshatriyas and Vaishyas grew curious:

"Something is going on here, and good things are happening to them too — siddhis, vidya, something is coming to them, there is some benefit."

But the rajasic temperament had no time:

"'I have no time; will you do it for us?'... The Vaishya also says, 'I have money; you do it, I'll give you dakshina.'"

The rishis' original answer is of great importance:

"Arre, it doesn't work like that. I am giving thanks for what I have received from nature. **You will have to give your own thanks.** I can teach you that vidya, I can bring it down into you — from Surya to Manu, from Manu to Ikshvaku — **I may guide you, I may be your teacher.**"

(From Surya to Manu, from Manu to Ikshvaku — an allusion to knowledge descending through the line of teacher and disciple.)

But the insistence grew, and in the end the Brahmin assembly accepted:

"You're getting a cow for free, so take it — what does it cost you?"

Along with this, the knowledge of how to perform sadhana for someone else also developed:

"Then how to do it while meditating on that person's mind — that is given in Patanjali... that by meditating on another, some exchange of my tapasya will take place."

For a while everyone was content:

"The king was happy, the Vaishya was happy, all the others who served were happy too — at least we found someone to do puja for us. **Nobody learned it; only they knew.** Since then that karmakanda, karmakanda has been going on."

5. When Worship Became Mechanical

Generations changed, and the purpose was lost:

"The Brahmin two or three generations later learned mechanically that their puja has to be performed. And the other learned that dakshina has to be given to the Brahmin."

"This one forgot for whom he was doing the puja; that one forgot why he was giving the dakshina. Now both were mechanical — one performed mechanical puja, the other gave mechanical dakshina."

Then others copied the outer ritual as well:

"He only offers this much in flowers, he does this, he does that — so I can do this too. **Not the atma-tattva part, not the purpose.**"

This is one of the central lessons of the chapter: when an action is separated from its **purpose**, it remains only mechanical ritual — which anyone can copy.

6. Many Deities, Many Pujas: The Veda Evolves Again

Seeing their knowledge copied, the Brahmins took a new direction:

"Now this intellect had stagnated, and our business was gone too. **Now we have to evolve further.**"

"Keeping just one deity like this won't work. Now we'll have many deities. Do you want a house? Then this puja. Do you want a car? Then this puja. Do you want a son? Then this puja."

But Acharya Ji does not see this as mere deception — he calls it a real evolution of the Veda:

"But it was not meant to trap anyone. That was evolution — the Veda is evolving, understand? It is getting evolved."

"Necessity is the mother of invention... I'm not saying this was done to trap people either — **the intellect genuinely evolved.**"

But history repeated itself:

"Again four or five generations passed for both, and both forgot again... And at the end it became, like today, a **multi-billion dollar business.**"

7. The Rebellion of Rishi Yajnavalkya

When the evolution of the Veda stopped again, one sage raised the question:

"Rishi Yajnavalkya, being from a Brahmin family, did not like this. He says, '**What was the aim? Self-realisation.** For what did our ancestors start this?... This doesn't seem right to me. We will have to oppose it.'"

His guru cited tradition:

"Even if it seems wrong, you will still have to do this, because this has now become the tradition. Now this has become a business, so it's business."

Yajnavalkya did not accept this, and his guru asked him to return the knowledge he had been given:

"'If you don't accept it, then give back the vidya I gave you first, and then go.' It is said that he did **vamana**, that is, something like vomiting — symbolic of — giving back all that knowledge. 'Now I will discover something new of my own.'"

"Then he immediately goes into meditation, and **he realised some higher truths** — all this is not in here; there is something a little higher than this."

But the established order opposed him. According to Acharya Ji, this is how the Yajurveda came to be divided:

"They made a division — what the Brahmins do was given the name Shukla Yajurveda, and what he had was called black, all wrong — so Krishna Yajurveda."

Yajnavalkya was cast out of society — but his search did not stop:

"And he had to go to some forest. He had to go to the jungle, to the **aranya**. But he continued his research — the knowing still went on."

8. Aranyaka and Upanishad: The Summit of the Veda

The knowledge received in the forest became the third part of the Veda:

"Then whatever he came to understand, he gave back to society after some time — his time also had to come. That part of the Veda is called Aranyaka."

(Aranyaka — the portion connected with the **aranya**, the forest.)

"From that very Aranyaka arose the Upanishad named **Brihadaranyaka**, and the **Chandogya Upanishad**... which is a mixture of both — a little of the ritual section will come, the body will come, and the Self will come too."

And Acharya Ji ties the whole sequence of this journey into one sentence:

"So first **Mantra Samhita, Brahmana, Aranyaka**, and beyond even this — on the basis of Rishi Yajnavalkya's knowledge — **the part by which one knew the Self became the Upanishad**. So this is the sequence."

9. The Message of the Gita: Rise Above the Three Gunas

Shri Krishna gives the conclusion of this whole journey of the Vedas in the Gita:

**traiguṇya-viṣayā vedā nistraiguṇyo bhavārjuna,
nirdvandvo nitya-sattva-stho niryoga-kṣema
ātmavān.**

"The Vedas deal with the subjects of the three
gunas; O Arjuna, rise above the three gunas — free
from the pairs of opposites, ever established in
sattva, free from concern for acquiring and keeping,
and established in the Self."

— Bhagavad Gita 2.45

Acharya Ji opens up this verse word by word:

"Go above all of this... **nirdvandvo** — dvandva means
the pairs: cold and heat, gain and loss, victory and
defeat, honour and dishonour — rise above these."

"**nitya-sattva-stho** — so it says not to take up the actions
of rajas and tamas... Where will you find sattva? **With a
genuine guru.**"

"**niryoga-kṣema** — give up even the worry about my yoga and kshema — what I am to get, what I am to keep. Then your guru will look after that."

(**Yoga** — acquiring what one does not have; **kshema** — protecting what one has.) And Shri Krishna repeats this assurance later:

**ananyāś cintayanto mām ye janāḥ paryupāsate,
teṣāṁ nityābhiyuktānām yoga-kṣemaṁ vahāmy
aham.**

"Those who worship Me, thinking of Me with undivided devotion — for them, ever united with Me, I Myself carry what they need and preserve what they have."

— Bhagavad Gita 9.22

"'I will look after you.' So Krishna takes you there."

10. "Don't Read Me": The Unique Voice of the

Veda

In the same context, pointing to the verses just before this one (Chapter 2), Acharya Ji says something startling:

"Veda is the only scripture in the world which shouts and tells, 'Don't read me.'"

"Now you call it the book of the Hindus, and Shri Krishna is our God, and the Gita is his guide — and he says not to read it... How shocked were you to hear that?"

"The Veda — of Sanatan Dharma — from the mouth of Shri Krishna he says: **one who reads it is a fool; the deluded one reads the Veda.**"

But this does not mean abandoning the Veda:

"But one who reads Vedanta — that too is the Veda, isn't it? Read only that much of the Veda."

"Out of 100 pages, 96 pages were to be ignored, and you were to come straight to the last four pages. **That means one had to come to some guru and learn this final vidya.**"

Summary: Key Teachings

- 1 The Veda is an evolving journey** — Mantra Samhita, Brahmana, Aranyaka and Upanishad emerged one by one, along with humanity's growing understanding.
- 2 The Mantra Samhita was born of gratitude** — the rishis saw the sincerity of nature, and **It is high time I should appreciate** — composition arose on its own from their praise.
- 3 Love is expressed in action** — praise alone is not enough; from this understanding came the Brahmana portion, with yajna, dana, tapa and the methods of worship.
- 4 Religion began with nature worship and ancestor worship** — whatever could be seen was worshipped; the journey from form to the formless.

- 5 **"You will have to give your own thanks"** — the rishis' original spirit was that every person should be grateful themselves; the guru is only the guide.
- 6 **Forgetting the purpose makes action mechanical** — both puja and dakshina became mechanical, and the atma-tattva was left behind.
- 7 **The courage of Rishi Yajnavalkya** — standing against tradition and the lobby, he continued the search for Self-realisation, from which the Aranyakas and Upanishads emerged.
- 8 **Nistraiguṇyo bhavārjuna** — rise above the three gunas and the pairs of opposites, stay established in sattva with a genuine guru, and leave the worry of yoga-kshema to the guru.
- 9 **The essence of the Veda is Vedanta** — leave 96 of the 100 pages and come to the last four, that is, learn that final vidya from a guru.